Interview Transcript – Participant I

Study: Early Value Challenges for Non-Technical Users of AI Automation Builders

Date: 27 March 2026
Duration: ~30+ minutes (recording truncated by transcription limit)
Interviewer: J (researcher)
Participant: I (pseudonym)
Participant Role: Revenue Operations Manager at a mid-sized European B2B SaaS company in the mental well-being space. Responsible for optimising the full commercial process from marketing through to customer success, including tooling, internal process design, and automation. Has a background in analytics and data-oriented roles. Some programming exposure during university studies but not a software engineering background — describes himself as working primarily with no-code and AI-assisted solutions rather than writing code by hand. AI automation now accounts for approximately 60–70% of his day-to-day work.
Anonymization note: All identifying information (full name, employer name, specific tool brand names where used as identifiers) has been removed or replaced with neutral descriptors. Note: recording was truncated by the transcription service before the interview concluded.

I: This topic diligently, collecting consent and everything.

J: Yeah, I have to do it. Let me see, I have the questions over here. Alright, yeah, so — could you introduce yourself and briefly describe what your day-to-day responsibilities are?

I: Of course, yeah, so I work for a mental well-being platform that helps companies normalise mental well-being for their employees. So we give access to employees to the platform where they can find help — therapists, but also other types of support. And what I do, what my role is at the company, is revenue operations. So basically, starting from the first awareness that we create within the marketing team, up until closing the contract with the client and then expanding that client and providing customer support and customer success. This entire process I am supporting all the internal employees with, in terms of their way of working, in terms of the process that they follow, and trying to optimise that process and make all the tools and internal processes actually work for people and not against them. So if you look at my day-to-day, it's a lot of automation. It's a lot of mapping out internal processes, trying to see where we can optimise things. And these days, of course, there's a huge AI wave. I would say these days AI is around 60–70% of my job. And then another 30% is some ad hoc stuff that happens when there are non-ordinary situations. But yeah, it's a lot of process optimisation and automation.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah. So we kind of already got to this question, but how would you describe your technical background? Do you have experience with programming or building things digitally?

I: Well, during my university days I did a bit of programming. And of course you use all these tools for thesis work and so on. But it was not that I was a computer science major or anything like that. But if I look at code, I'm able to understand what it does. So I have this way of thinking that I inherited from my studies. And then, yeah, when I started in various roles, I always worked within the analytics domain — always working with numbers, tables, automations, and stuff like that. And I would always lean towards no-code solutions. Back in the early days I was using a workflow automation platform. And within different CRM systems you always have some automation workflow builders — you can always build some automations around different processes. So that's what I started with. And then when the AI wave started, that enabled me to also apply code. So that's when I started using visual automation tools much more. But that didn't last long. Because now it's way easier to just generate a piece of code with an AI coding assistant and just publish your own piece of software without relying on all these building blocks. So this is a bit like my path. But I am not writing code by hand. And hopefully the best developers in the world don't do it either anymore.

J: Okay, nice. And yeah, what were you actually trying to accomplish when you first started using an automation tool? What was the task, what was the goal?

I: Yeah, I think the first time I started using it, it was mostly around marketing automation and marketing processes — outreach, marketing emails, webinar management. Like: we're running a webinar, we need to make sure that we store all the information about people who signed up, people who cancelled, people who need some follow-up. So it was all around that. And also the CRM systems were not that advanced back then. So I had to take all the different elements from different tools and connect them all into one system that would work. So that was kind of my first use case at my first job.

J: Yeah, okay. And before you opened your first AI automation tool, what did you think it would be able to do for you? What were your expectations?

I: I think it's important to distinguish between AI automation tools and just automation tools. When I opened a basic automation tool for the first time, it was like six, seven years ago — far from what we'd call an AI automation tool today. But if I open an AI automation tool now, I expect it to do everything I can imagine. The sky is the limit, and your own imagination is the limit. You just need to scope correctly what exactly you want. And I automatically decompose everything into elements. Even before I start prompting or trying to build something, I already need to understand how it would work. So I expected to just build everything I would be able to imagine.

J: Okay, nice. So when you think back to your very first session — because I think I'm most interested in AI automation tools specifically, not just general automation tools. So if you think back to your first session with an AI automation tool, could you walk me through what happened in that session, step by step?

I: Yeah, so what I struggle with is: what exactly counts as an AI automation tool? Because a visual automation tool can be called an AI automation tool, but still while working with it I was generating all the code in an AI assistant. And then I'd just paste it into the visual tool. Or I'd generate the entire workflow in the AI assistant and let it publish directly. But yeah, I can reflect on my first experience when I started using AI for automation. I think it was the feeling of a complete unlock. Because what I was always used to is that you would always be limited by the design of the system. So if you build something with a traditional automation tool, normally you would have these pre-built connectors to everything. And then you would always run into issues — not being able to populate a certain value, not being able to trigger on a specific event, not being able to access a platform that just doesn't have an integration yet. All of these things would make it a nightmare because you would always need workarounds. And when I first started using a visual automation tool together with an AI model, I could just generate pieces of code and inject them into the nodes of the workflow. And that was just a super freeing feeling because I could call any API. I could transform data the way I want. It would speed me up at least ten times. And that was my first moment — before I even realised that I can just generate the entire flow with AI without even building it myself. But these were still the early days of AI. I couldn't think that far yet.

J: Okay, yeah. Yeah, so could you explain what a specific automation is that you built with an AI automation tool?

I: Yeah, I think the very first one was a call meeting note-taking automation. We use a call recording and transcription tool internally, which records and transcribes all meetings. It has a built-in feature for summarising calls and posting to a CRM or other integrated system. But there was no customisation option back then — you couldn't specify in what way you wanted the summary. So it would always summarise everything, but I'm not interested in what my own salespeople say. I'm interested in what the other person is saying — those are the notes I want. And it was impossible to adjust it to focus on what the other person said. So that was the first automation I built with a visual tool. We would trigger through a webhook whenever a transcript was ready. That would kick off the automation that would pull the transcript, put it into an LLM based on a specific prompt I came up with, it would analyse it, add it to the CRM, and send a notification to the user. So that was the very first one.

J: Yeah, cool. Yeah, so when you build automation using AI, do you always understand what is happening? Do you understand how the AI comes up with the code it uses?

I: I think when I was still building with the visual tool, I was trying to. I was always trying to follow step by step and even come up with the logic myself of what needs to happen. So back then, yes. But now I don't think it's feasible anymore. Even for people who know how to code and are actual developers, I don't think it's feasible to comprehend the amount of code that is being generated. But what you can still control is the general architecture and structure of what you're building. So this is something I try to be very diligent with — so it doesn't create some random piece of code that makes no sense, but it needs to make sense from an architecture perspective and I need to understand what is happening at the backend, at least at a high level. And this is also something I can ask AI to explain when the code is generated. I can say: walk me through step by step what is happening. And if I see that it has drifted from the original idea or become too complex, I try to challenge it to rewrite in a way that is more understandable.

J: Yeah, okay. And that works most of the time if you do it like that?

I: For me, yes. So far it's been quite good. And also sometimes what we find quite efficient is: I generate something with one AI coding tool, but then I let a different AI model review what the first one came up with — to challenge it so that it's not biased. There's a different LLM looking at it. And then there's this kind of ping-pong feedback loop happening.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah, so do you always feel in control when you build an automation? Do you always feel in control of what is happening and how the automation is running?

I: Well, not entirely in control. So if something breaks, I will not be able to fix it by hand anymore. In that way, I'm not in control. I would need to debug it again with the help of AI, so that it finds the issue and resolves it. However, with a visual automation tool, if a workflow fails, you also cannot easily debug that. So it's kind of a similar level of not being fully in control.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah, so you don't feel in control when failures happen sometimes, but the automation itself — the one you built — you feel in control of that?

I: Yeah, because in the beginning when you build it, you also test it of course. You test how everything works and I try to come up with different edge cases of how and when it could break. So once everything is tested, occasionally a new edge case comes up. But in general I haven't really experienced automations doing random things I can't explain — that has actually never really happened to me.

J: Yeah, so you also never really worry about making a mistake that could negatively affect your work when building an automation?

I: I think here, what is important to understand is the nature of my work, because it's mostly internal-facing. So I can be a bit more risky when it comes to building automations, because if something does not work, the end client is not affected. It's like: one of the internal people will flag it to me — hey, this thing failed — but it's not something that will harm the experience for the end user. So that makes me a bit more relaxed about this topic. But of course, in terms of privacy, security, and all of that, it is still a topic. So I am checking everything about how it is configured to not make any major mistakes or data leaks.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah, so if you get stuck, how do you try to get unstuck? Do you use documentation, for example, or do you just mostly prompt with AI? What is your method?

I: Yeah, so I think mostly I just try to decompose the issue I'm having into different elements to understand what exactly is breaking. And then I try to direct AI towards the right path, because sometimes you go into a rabbit hole where it starts confusing itself. So I just try to direct AI in the right direction. Or sometimes I even realise that this is not going to the right destination and I just need to start from scratch. But most of the time it's not that I figure it out fully myself and read documentation myself. I can quickly look something up, see that documentation in general exists, and then I send AI to read all the documentation and make conclusions for me — because it's way faster and I know it will actually read it and understand it better than I do.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah, so if you can still remember your first session — at the end of that first session, did you feel like you had accomplished something useful in trying to automate something?

I: Well, I think it was multiple sessions. The first thing I built was the note-taker. And yeah, we still use that every single day, many times per day, with a lot of people. So that works very, very well. And since then I've built a lot of extra add-ons to it — it now also drafts emails, for example. But yeah, it was multiple days of building and debugging. About four days in total, I think. But by the end of it, yes — I felt that it was incredible. It works really well.

J: Yeah. OK, nice. And if the tool could have done one thing differently to make its first user experience better, do you have any ideas for what that could be?

I: It's hard to be unbiased about all these AI automation tools. But I think what I like — in one AI coding tool there's a feature called plan mode. Do you know about that?

J: No, I actually don't know.

I: So there's a separate mode you can turn on which helps you come up with the first requirements document for the project. It helps you come up with the first prompt that your project will be built on. And it helps you plan the project based on everything you want to achieve. So you give it quite an extensive overview of what you want to build — you can be very freeform about it. And then it walks you through a set of questions about the tech stack, specific features, and so on. And by the end of this exercise, it actually generates an overview of what you want to build in an AI-friendly way, so that when it hands it over to the actual building tool, that tool understands you better. So maybe this is something that would help especially basic users who have never worked with automation tools — they would just be able to exchange ideas and explain in plain text what they want to build, what they want to achieve, and then receive guidance from the tool itself. But I think this is also where other automation tools are going now. It kind of becomes obsolete to move different blocks yourself — you can just describe what you want and it gets built for you.

J: Yeah. Very good one. Nice. So — yeah, this first experience of making your first automation. Those four days. Did that whole experience change how willing you are to try automating other things in your work?

I: Oh, for sure. For sure. Because it felt like — yeah, indeed — the sky is the limit and you can literally automate everything now. Of course your brain starts processing all this and coming up with new ideas all the time. So yeah, definitely I'm more willing to work on this. I was always quite willing to work on automations because it's part of my job and something I genuinely enjoy. But now it's just a major unlock because all the things I was not able to do before — limited by the number of people at the company or some technical limitations — I can literally do anything now. The only thing I need to tackle all the time is this kind of overwhelming feeling of too many ideas and not knowing where to start. I think that's something a lot of people are experiencing these days. But you just do it step by step, one use case at a time. And then yeah — definitely more energised. Sometimes you cannot even sleep because you have so many ideas.

J: Okay, cool. Yeah, so are there any challenges you haven't mentioned yet that you encountered while using an AI automation tool?

I: I think when it comes to challenges — I'm not sure if it's relevant for you or not, because it's about the end outcome of the AI automation tool. And my personal pain is the collaborative aspect. Because I feel like all the tools that are made available these days are kind of targeted towards you personally, but not towards a team collaborating on that. So for instance, if you look at a personal AI assistant tool, you can connect your email, your calendar, your CRM — whatever you want to automate, you can set it up for yourself. But then my biggest challenge right now is: how do I also, in a streamlined way, onboard my team on how they need to set it up for themselves? So that all of them have the most up-to-date knowledge about the company, about all the workflows we have internally, and that we have some best practices of how to use that. And that it is individual per person — so it knows every single person individually and has memory about every individual person — but at the same time we share common ways of working. This is something I haven't fully cracked yet. I think the tools are moving in that direction, but I haven't fully cracked how to enable that within the team.

J: Okay. Yeah, so I think I already got a lot of useful insights. Yeah, do you have any things you want to add? Any ideas that you haven't mentioned yet?

I: Yeah, well, maybe just to repeat myself about AI automation tools — I find it very interesting how there was a huge spike in visual automation tool popularity because there was this huge unlock: actually writing code with an AI model and then pasting it into blocks. And then how quickly it shifted towards: okay, now I can just generate my code without a visual tool at all. And the visual tool can even be a blocker because if your workflow becomes super large and you want an LLM to help you adjust the workflow, you don't get enough context window anymore for an LLM to evaluate the entire workflow. So then it's easier to just develop something directly with an AI coding tool and ship that new feature. So it is just very interesting and fascinating to see this shift happening — from really automation towards something where you can just describe what you want and it will be done without even an automation tool. For instance, if I think about the first automation I built — the note-taker — now I can go to an AI agent tool and just say: from now on, every time my meeting ends in my calendar, go to the transcription tool five minutes after and transcribe this meeting with a certain prompt. And I just write this message and it literally replaces the entire workflow I built in the visual tool. [Recording ends]